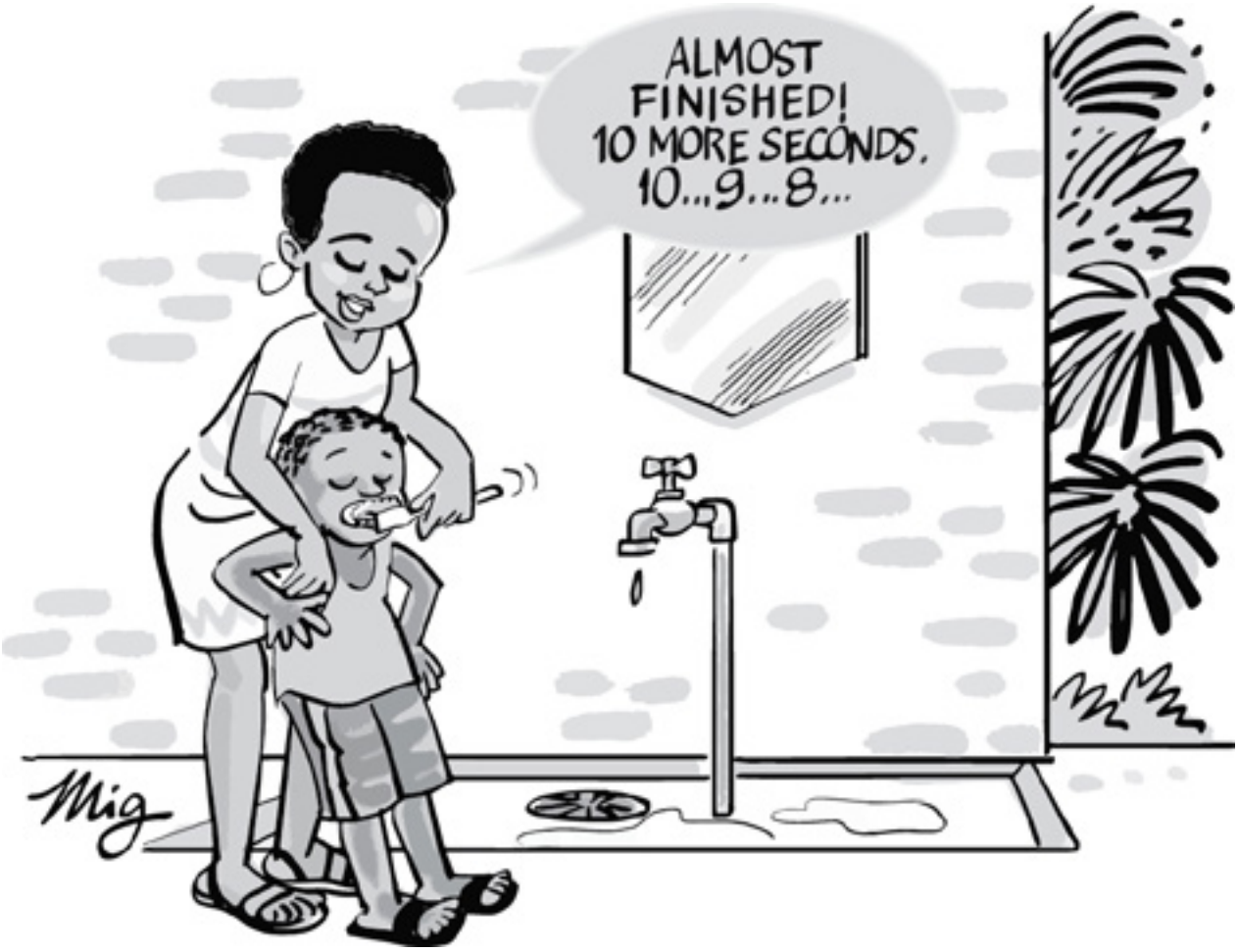
8

Session 8: Teaching alternatives to challenging behaviour



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Overview

		Date, time, location
Home visit 1		
Call to check in		
Session 1	**Introduction – Getting children engaged**	
Call to check in		
Session 2	**Keeping children engaged**	
Call to check in		
Session 3	**Helping children to share engagement in play and home routines**	
Text message reminder about next session		
Session 4	**Understanding communication**	
Text message reminder about next session		
Session 5	**Promoting communication**	
Home visit 2 (between sessions 5 and 6)		
Session 6	**Teaching new skills in small steps and levels of help**	
Text message reminder about next session		
Session 7	**Preventing challenging behaviour – helping children to stay engaged and regulated**	
Call to check in		
Session 8	**Teaching alternatives to challenging behaviour**	
Text message reminder about next session		
Session 9	**Problem-solving and self-care**	
Home visit 3		
Additional sessions		

Home practice review

Our target routines were:

1) _____

2) _____

Our target challenging behaviour was:

_____

_____

_____

To reduce/stop the behaviour I tried to:

_____

_____

_____

I think the behaviour happened because:

_____

_____

_____

What we will learn today

- **More about how to manage challenging behaviour.**
- **How to identify challenging behaviours and help your child to decrease these behaviours.**

Personal goals

The two target routines I plan to do with my child this week are:

1) _____

_____

_____

2) _____

_____

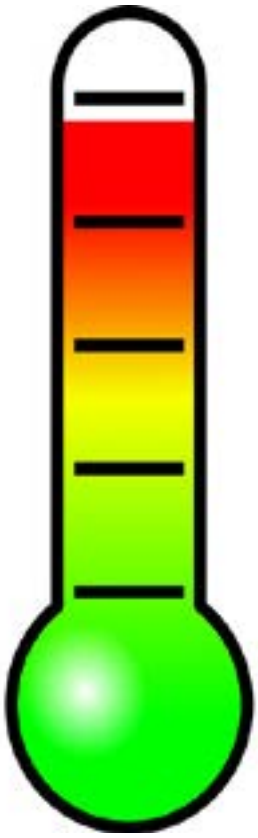
_____

	Want to see more (appropriate behaviour)	Want to see less often (challenging behaviour)
Routine 1:		
Routine 2:		

Today we will plan how to respond to these challenging behaviours.

The behaviour thermometer

What did you notice about your child's behaviour this week?



My child is hot/red when:

_____

_____

_____

_____

Hot/ red

Very upset, angry or overexcited. Needing help to calm down.

My child is warm/yellow when:

_____

_____

_____

_____

Warm/yellow

Showing first signs of frustration, distress, upset.

My child is cool/green when:

_____

_____

_____

_____

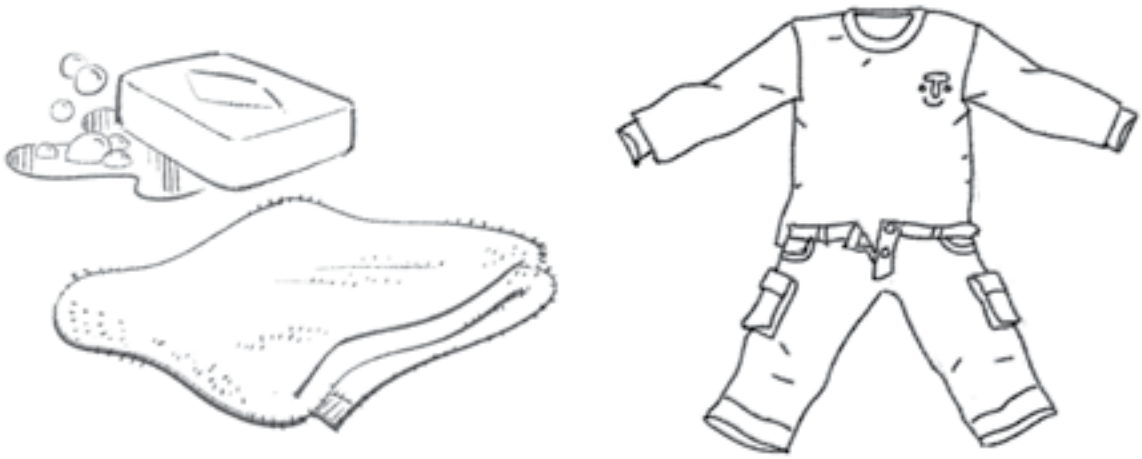
Cool/ green

Calm, alert and ready to learn.

Tip 1

Use picture schedules to help your child to understand activities and stay calm

- ***First–then*** **schedules show your child what is happening now and what will happen next.**



- **You can show the two pictures to the child and say, "First we wash our face and hands, and then we put on clothes."**
- **Pictures schedules help to warn your child that a change is coming.**
- **This can lower anxiety and stress about what will happen next.**

Activity or day schedules show your child many steps at a time

This after-school schedule has a picture for each step the child will do once she/he comes home:

Take off shoes

Have something to eat

Pick up brother

Play

Four goals for responding to challenging behaviour

Reason for the behaviour **goal for responding**

To get access to something

Help the child to use communication skills to ask (by using a gesture, sign, picture, or saying a word) OR – if you do not wish to provide the item – be consistent and do not give the item when there is challenging behaviour.

To get attention

Give no attention or response for challenging behaviour (ignore the behaviour) …

... AND reward appropriate behaviour and skills with praise and attention.

REASON FOR THE BEHAVIOUR

GOAL FOR RESPONDING

To stop or avoid something

Set clear, consistent and appropriate expectations and help your child to understand that challenging behaviour will not stop the activity.

To get a sensation

Provide a safe and appropriate way of getting the sensation ...

... AND help your child to communicate to get the sensation she/he wants.

Maya's story

Look and listen for:

1) What happens ***before*** the behaviour.

2) The challenging behaviour.

3) What happens ***after*** the behaviour.

What is the message the child is sending with the challenging behaviour?
Notice how the caregiver responds.

Maya's mother has been working on a tooth-brushing routine every night. Maya does not like brushing her teeth. Her mother reminds her that it is time to brush her teeth before she goes to bed. Maya ignores her mother's reminder and continues to play around with her brother.

Maya's mother waits for a couple of minutes and then asks Maya again to brush her teeth. Maya whines to have a few more minutes to play before bed. Sometimes Maya's mother lets her have more time to avoid the battle over brushing her teeth.

Sometimes she tells her "No" and asks her again to brush her teeth. When she does this, Maya sometimes cries, screams and flops to the floor. Sometimes Maya's mother gives up and does not make her brush her teeth.

Luc’s story

Look and listen for:

1) What happens ***before*** the behaviour.

2) The challenging behaviour.

3) What happens ***after*** the behaviour.

What is the message the child is sending with the challenging behaviour?
Notice how the caregiver responds.

Louis-Philippe has a job that requires him to make a lot of telephone calls. He tries to make his calls while his son Luc is at school but calls still need to be made when Luc is at home. When Louis-Philippe answers the telephone, Luc begins to yell for his dad loudly “Dad, dad! Look at this! Dad, dad!” and runs around the house.

Louis-Philippe tries to continue the call but eventually Luc’s running and yelling are so loud that Louis-Philippe tells his son loudly to stop or tries to get Luc to sit quietly with him while still on the telephone.

Key message 1

Find out the reason for your child's challenging behaviour and decide how to respond based on that reason (to get access or attention, to avoid or to get a sensation)

There are four reasons for challenging behaviour:

Get access

Get attention

Avoid or stop something

Get a sensation

- **Think about what happened before, during and after the behaviour to find out the reason for the behaviour**
- **There are different things you can do to decrease or stop these challenging behaviours, depending on the reason for the behaviour**

Challenging behaviour to get access to something

Example of an incorrect response that will increase challenging behaviour

Behaviour can help children get access to something they want

Why should we respond in a different way?

Giving children what they want when they scream and cry, without teaching them a new way to request, will not help them to learn to use words and gestures to communicate.

How to respond to challenging behaviour that aims to get access to something

When you want the child to have the item, help the child use communication skills (a gesture, sign, picture, or saying a word)

When you do not wish to give the item, do not give in. Be consistent, do not give the child the item while the child is showing challenging behaviour.

Tip 2

Respond to challenging behaviour that aims to get access by teaching your child to use communication skills

- **Respond to challenging behaviour that aims to get access by teaching your child to use communication skills:**
  - **words**
  - **gestures**
  - **sign language**
  - **pointing to a picture of the item.**
- ***Show and say* – demonstrate words and gestures your child can use to communicate.**
- **Work on communication strategies each day when your child is cool, calm and ready to learn. This way you can help your child to build the skills she/he needs to replace the challenging behaviour.**

1

She notices his behaviour to get access (crying and reaching) and responds by using *show and say* – she demonstrates words ("Want snack!") and a gesture (pointing) he can use to request.

2

Then she waits for a moment to give him room to try these communication skills.

Tip 2, continued

He doesn't try the new skills this time, but goes back to the same behaviour to get access (crying and reaching).

She responds to his communication (crying and reaching) by giving him the snack right away. She also repeats the words he can use to request ("Want snack!"). She doesn't need to wait for him to try the words and gesture before she gives the snack.

Much later

After she works on communication skills each day and responds to his behaviour many, many times with words and gestures, he makes a sound and reaches out his hand to request!

She is very excited to see this and responds by giving him the snack right away and saying the words he can use to request ("Want snack!")

Challenging behaviour that seeks attention

- **Behaviour can help a child get attention from someone.**
- **Attention can be positive (looking at the child, talking to the child or engaging in the activity) or negative (scolding, yelling, physically moving the child).**
- **Responding to challenging behaviour by giving attention to the child will make it more likely to happen again**.

How to respond to challenging behaviour that seeks attention

Ignore: Do not look at the child or talk to the child while you are waiting for the challenging behaviour to stop.

When the challenging behaviour stops, praise the child right away, even for something very small, such as sitting and being quiet for a few seconds.

Tip 3

Ignore challenging behaviour that is seeking attention if it is safe and okay to do so

Ask yourself:

- **Could the behaviour hurt my child or another person?**
- **Is my child scared, hurt or sick (i.e. in need of my attention)?**

If your answer to both questions is "No", you can ignore the behaviour.

Do not look at the child, talk to the child or shout while you are waiting for the challenging behaviour to stop (this would reward the child with attention).

Remember that when you begin to ignore behaviour to get attention, it will usually get worse before it gets better. This is because your child will usually try harder to get you to notice her/him.

When the challenging behaviour stops, praise your child right away, even for something very small, such as sitting and being quiet for a few seconds.

Challenging behaviour to stop or avoid something

Behaviour can help a child stop or avoid something that she/he does not like.

How to respond to challenging behaviour to avoid something

If the routine is challenging for your child, try to:

- **make the routine easier for your child;**
- **offer help;**
- **use picture schedules;**
- **use countdowns or timers.**

If your child can do the activity, be clear, kind and firm.
Help your child to understand that challenging behaviour will not stop the activity.

Tip 4

Set clear, consistent and appropriate expectations to reduce challenging behaviour that aims to avoid or stop a routine

- **"Clear" – Use words your child can understand.**
- **"Consistent" – Expect the same thing from your child each time and increase your expectations slowly over time.**
- **"Appropriate" – Choose activities and routines at the right level for your child:**
  - **If the activity is too difficult, make it easier or more fun for your child, offering help, praising, setting up the space, singing or finding an easier time to do the activity.**
  - **If the activity is too easy, make it more interesting by varying the materials or teaching new steps.**

Challenging behaviour to get access to a sensation

Behaviour can help a child get sensation (a feeling)

A child tries to touch strangers' clothing because the child likes the feeling of fabric.

A child chews on things that are dirty or unsafe, such as items from the ground.

How to respond to challenging behaviour to get a sensation

Choose a more appropriate way to give the child the sensation.

For a child who tries to touch strangers' clothing because the child likes the feeling of fabric:

Provide the child with a piece of fabric they can touch instead.

Teach the child to ask for the piece of fabric using words or gestures.

For a child who chews on things that are dirty or unsafe, such as items from the ground:

Create a necklace that the child can chew on by putting some flexible plastic tubing on a string.

Teach the child to chew on the necklace instead of dirty or unsafe things.

Tip 5

Teach a safe and appropriate behaviour to replace sensation-seeking challenging behaviour.

- ***Ask yourself:*** **Does this behaviour put my child at risk? Does this behaviour disrupt my child's engagement and learning? If not, think about focusing first on another challenging behaviour.**
- **Teach a safe and appropriate behaviour to give access to the same sensation. This behaviour will replace the current challenging behaviour.**
- **Teach your child to ask to get the sensation they want.**

A child touches a stranger's clothing because the child likes to touch fabric.

Give the child a piece of fabric to touch instead and teach the child to ask for it using words or gestures.

Before, During and After Behaviour chart for Session 8

Before	During (the behaviour)	After	Reason for behaviour	How to reduce the behaviour
What happened immediately before the behaviour?	How did the child behave?	What happened immediately after the behaviour?	What was the reason for the behaviour?	What could you do to prevent the behaviour? How should you respond based on the reason for the behaviour?
▪ Did you ask your child to do something? ▪ Was there a change in activities? ▪ Was a favourite toy or item not available?	▪ Crying and lying on the floor? ▪ Refusing to collaborate with an important task? ▪ Screaming "no"?	▪ Did you give attention (positive or negative)? ▪ Did you give your child access to something? ▪ Did you stop the activity?	▪ To get access to something ▪ To get attention ▪ To avoid or stop something ▪ To get a sensation	▪ Teach words and gestures for requesting. ▪ Ignore behaviour if it is safe and OK to do so. ▪ Set clear, consistent and appropriate expectations. ▪ Teach a new way to get a sensation.

Home practice activity

- **Choose 2 everyday activities (home routines) that you will do with your child or involve your child in.** These could be the same activities you did before, or something different. Choose something you do each day. When you do the activity, plan to spend at least 5 minutes with your child and notice and respond to your child's communication.
- **Look and listed for challenging behaviours and their signals.**
  Think about what happens before, during and after the challenging behaviour.

Use the plan you made to respond to the challenging behaviour.

The target challenging behaviours are:

Activity 1

Behaviour:_____

Reason for behaviour:_____

Plan to respond:_____

Activity 2

Behaviour:_____

Reason for behaviour:_____

Plan to respond:_____

- **Remember to practise the tips from this session:**

Tips

1. Use picture schedules to help your child understand activities and stay calm.

2. Respond to challenging behaviour that aims to get access by teaching your child to use communication skills.

3. Ignore challenging behaviour that is seeking attention if it is safe and okay to do so.

4. Set clear, consistent and appropriate expectations to reduce challenging behaviour that aims to avoid or stop a routine.

5. Teach a safe and appropriate behaviour to replace sensation-seeking challenging behaviour.

Key messages

- Find out the reason for your child's challenging behaviour and decide how to respond based on that reason (to get access or attention, to avoid or to get a sensation).